CINEMA

ON A NEW HIGH



In Rajshri Productions' 75th year, Sooraj Barjatya's *Uunchai* tells the tale of an elderly group of friends who embark on a mission to the Everest base camp

Established in 1947, the family-run Rajshri Productions is synonymous with the value-laden family entertainer, best exemplified by *Hum Aapke Hain Koun* (1994) and *Hum Saath-Saath Hain* (1999). For the past three decades, Sooraj R. Barjatya, the third generation, has kept the ship sailing. November 11 marks the release of *Uunchai*, Rajshri's 60th film and Barjatya's seventh directorial venture. It features Amitabh Bachchan, Anupam Kher and Boman Irani as three sexagenarian friends who embark on a mission to fulfil their deceased friend's dream and make it to the Everest base camp. For Barjatya, the film is a stylistic departure from his previous work, including *Maine Pyar Kiya* (1989).



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MILIND SHELTE

"Most of my films are not character but moment-oriented. Things happen around a function," says Barjatya. "The characters [in *Uunchai*] are more real. The film is my way of telling the youth the power of courage and bonding. It is also my way of climbing a little bit as a filmmaker." But that's not to say *Uunchai* isn't the quintessential Rajshri film. "The storytelling will be different but like our emblem, Goddess Saraswati, there must be grace and learning," adds Barjatya.

The Barjatya clan—Sooraj's uncles Kamal and Ajit Kumar are financier and distributor, respectively—aims to please not just youngsters but even the grandparents' generation. So, expect no crass language or violence in a Rajshri film. The single-minded focus on the family stems from Sooraj Barjatya's upbringing in what he describes as a "spiritual" household. "The life we lead is reflected more or less in the films we make," he says.

But cinema has seen seismic shifts in the past decade. Clean family entertainers that made Rajshri one of the top studios in the 1990s are now hard to come by. Barjatya attributes it to changes in society. "There is a lot of 'I' and the 'we' is not there, which is also good because we should be independent. But there is distrust, and doubt in giving...we are seeing things breaking up a lot," he says. Some things, however, remain sacrosanct in Indian films. "In all the films that have done well, I notice that...the core is the human emotion. I try to grasp how the director has interpreted it," he adds.

Barjatya is willing to adapt to the times. When he started out, he says, he was told that cinema should "sell dreams", so his films had big houses, fancy cars and vacations. "Now everyone is living those dreams," he says. Today's audience wants "entertainment, but you have to give them something that makes them think higher". That challenge makes him feel more liberated than ever before. "Two decades back, we'd say, 'This is the structure, how do we fit a love story in it?' Today, the boundary is gone. I can now make a film on elderly people." ■

Suhani Singh